

PTI

**A REPRIEVE** Dileep leaves court after the court verdict, Dec. 8

# GHT ACQUITTAL

it will appeal in the high court.

The prosecution narrative was a dark parable that captured Kerala in moral horror. It had a superstar villain and three top actresses billed as wife, paramour and victim. Dileep held an old grudge against the last, the story went, for exposing his affair to his then wife. Dileep and Manju Warrier divorced in 2014; he married Kavya Madhavan in 2016. So the presumed 'exposé' can be roughly dated.

The incident cast as 'revenge' can be dated with certainty. On February 17, 2017, in Kochi, the victim was carjacked in her borrowed XUV by a group of six, led by Suni. She was sexually assaulted as the car coasted around the city. The criminals also videographed the brutal act before releasing her near her producer's home in Kakkanad on the city outskirts late at night.

Two days later, Dileep's ex-wife hinted at a larger conspiracy at a meeting of the Association of Malayalam Movie Artists (AMMA), convened to protest the incident. Her statement put the spotlight on Dileep and his alleged role.

Meanwhile, the Kochi city police made a hash of things, failing to nab the culprits for days even after the victim had revealed Suni's identity (many of them, including the prime suspect, were peripheral workers in the film industry). They also never found Suni's mobile phone, the one used to record the victim, though they did recover the memory card on which he had copied the visuals. The special investigation team (SIT) probing the case called Dileep in for questioning after discovering a letter Suni had written to him from jail demanding Rs 1.5 crore for the job done. On July 10, the actor was arrested and spent 85 days in judicial custody.

The case saw many twists and turns down the years, including two prosecution lead lawyers quitting, some 28 witnesses turning hostile, and much else. It got a second wind in 2021 after small-time director and ex-Dileep confidant, the late Balachandrakumar, came out and alleged that he had seen the star and a few others in a huddle watching Suni's video days after the incident.

The SIT also claimed it had proof that Dileep had met Suni at seven shooting locations, but the evidence didn't stand in court. "The courts need clinching proof. The conspiracy case against Dileep was weak," says high court lawyer and political analyst A. Jayashankar.

Leaving the court after his acquittal, Dileep told reporters his ex-wife, with her statement, and "some top officials" had conspired to frame him in the case. Later, talking to INDIA TODAY at his home in Aluva near Kochi, he said, "The Kerala police, along with a section of the media, cooked up stories against me. They wanted to ruin my career and my personal life." Top criminal lawyer B. Raman Pillai, who headed Dileep's five-member core defence team, went further, alleging the investigation headed by B. Sandhya (an IG who has since retired) framed his client. "In my five-decade-long legal career, I've never seen a chargesheet framed on such flimsy grounds. The SIT was piling up imaginary charges against Dileep," the 77-year-old legal luminary alleged.

The Mollywood superstar also has a number of prominent defenders, including Congress MP Adoor Prakash and the BJP's Thiruvananthapuram mayoral candidate and ex-DGP R. Sreelekha. Chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan, though, defended the SIT. "We are with the victim. He (Dileep) may say the police was framing him, but they had conducted a detailed investigation and took steps based on it. The state will appeal the verdict," says the CM. ■

**Takeaways**

- **After close to nine years, verdict nails perpetrators, but can't prove conspiracy angle**
- **Defendant Dileep alleges ex-wife's statement, 'top officials' framed him**